"We need multi-faceted coordination in Delhi-NCR"

In an exclusive interview with Avishek G. Dastidar, Union environment minister Bhupender Yadav says the Centre is looking at a 'whole of government' strategy to bring down pollution numbers. Excerpts:



Q. Pollution is choking Delhi. How can we break this annual cycle?
With policy interventions, the air quality in Delhi-NCR has improved in the past few years. Number of good days (AQI<200) rose to 200 days in 2025 from 110 in 2016. It has helped that the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) in Delhi-NCR has revisited the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) and made actions and infarction penalties more stringent. That said, greening of our degraded land to augment our carbon sinks will be critical. Under the National Clean Air Programme (NCAP), cities have been asked to prepare saturation-based action plans for various sectors.

Q. What is the single biggest challenge in NCR?
Well, we need multi-faceted coordination across Delhi, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and Punjab and various Union ministries. This must also extend to various central and state agencies such as state pollution control boards (SPCBs)/ pollution control committees (PCCs), urban local bodies (ULBs) etc. Without seamless collaboration among these entities, efforts remain fragmented and reactive. Hence the need for a 'whole of government' approach which harmonises enforcement, leverages tech, and empowers citizens in the fight.

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For instance, with constant efforts, stubble burning incidents are down almost 90 per cent in Punjab and Haryana, from 53,554 in 2022 to 5,771 in 2025. Vehicular pollution, and that from construction/demolition (C&D) activities, are the main culprits in NCR. We are working to augment the processing capacity of C&D waste processing facilities including offtake of recycled products for reuse

FARM FIRES

FAILURE
FARMERS BURN STUBBLE AFTER DARK, EVADING DETECTION. **NARROW SOWING WINDOWS, LABOUR SHORTAGES, DIESEL-POWERED MACHINERY**, POOR MANAGEMENT AND LOW ACCOUNTABILITY PERSIST

SOLUTION
USE GEOSTATIONARY SATELLITES FOR **ROUND-THE-CLOCK MONITORING TO CURB** NIGHT-TIME BURNING. SHIFT SUBSIDIES FROM EQUIPMENT PURCHASES TO OPERATING AND DEPRECIATION SUPPORT

To curb night-time crop burning and fix data gaps, experts advocate that India should use geostationary satellites for round-the-clock monitoring instead of twice-daily polar orbiters. Subsidies should shift from equipment purchases to operating and depreciation support, putting usable cash in farmers' hands to manage each acre without burning. Experts also recommend a uniform MSP regime to help farmers move away from paddy.

A Problem of Data-Shadow Zones

Roychowdhury highlights the data shadow zones in Delhi's 1,500-odd sq. km network of air quality monitoring network. The city's 40 AQI monitoring stations are spread lopsidedly along central and south Delhi, with large parts of the city—such as Northeast Delhi and industrial belts like Mundka-Bawana-Narela—largely unmonitored. A CAG audit also found 13 of them "mis-sited"—either too close to a tree, building or intersection—giving skewed readings. To eliminate these data shadow zones, the government should deploy a dense grid of low-cost sensors in unmonitored industrial and peripheral areas,